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Research

Investors see megatrends as an opportunity

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IMPORTANT RESEARCH DISCLOSURES LOCATED IN APPENDIX 1.

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We asked investors to explain why they are positive about investing in megatrends.

Our AI analysis of hundreds of responses is visualised in the word cloud below



This chartbook follows our [report](#) explaining how our new model analysing the impact of megatrends on economies and markets



We thank dbDataInsights for their contribution to this report

Source: dbDataInsights, Deutsche Bank.

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 - Geopolitics & globalisation
 - Domestic politics & social discontent
 - Demography
 - Energy disruption & transition

Our survey polled around 500 people in both the US and UK. The sample was designed to be representative of the population – not just a selection of investment professionals.

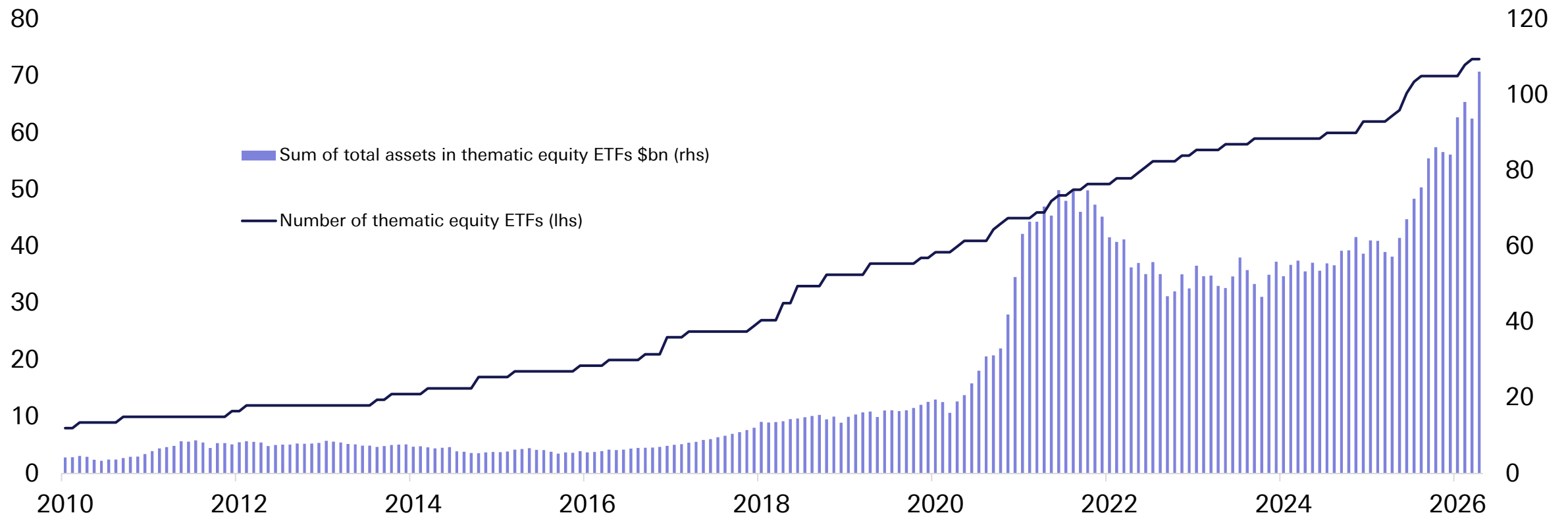
Thematic investing has been particularly strong in the 2020s

AI has also catalysed a rush of money flowing into thematic funds



The rise of thematic investing

Thematic equity funds and their AuM



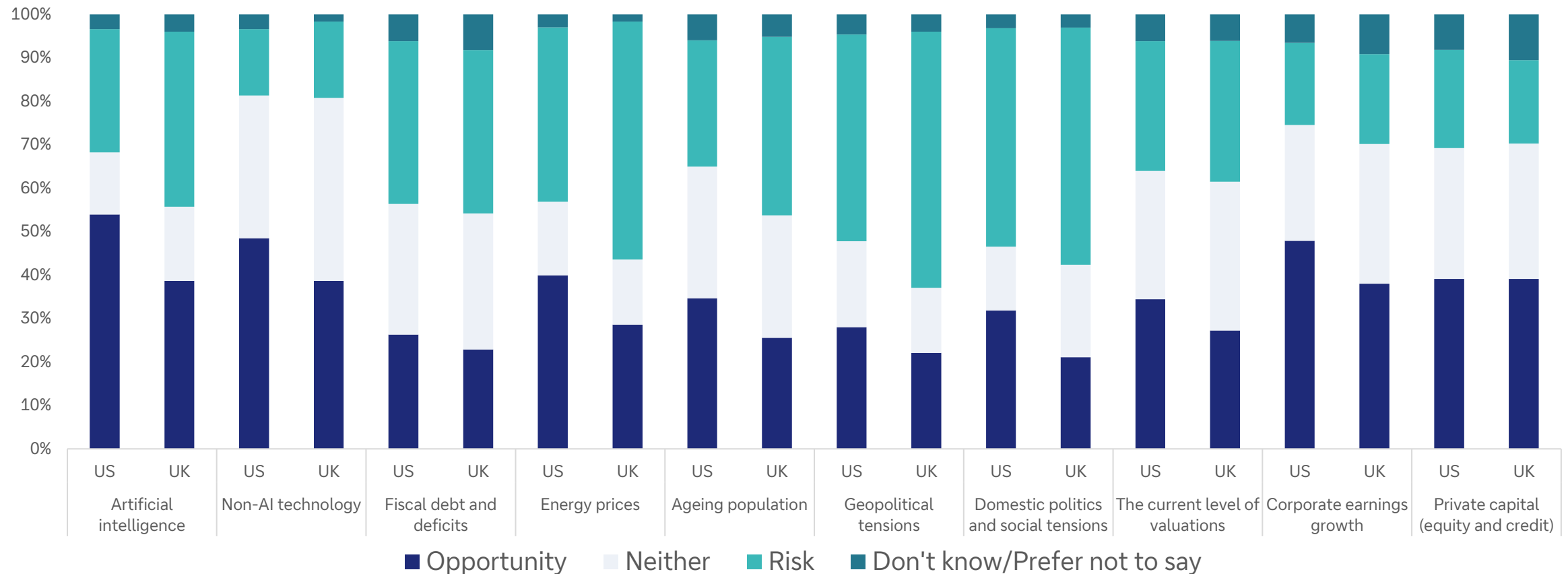
Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P., Deutsche Bank.

Tech – both AI and non-AI – are the strongest themes for investors

The similarity in the popularity of both AI and corporate earnings growth suggests that investors are happy to take a long-term position on AI regardless of the current capex requirements



“For each investment theme listed below, please indicate whether you perceive it as a risk or an opportunity for investors in 2026.”



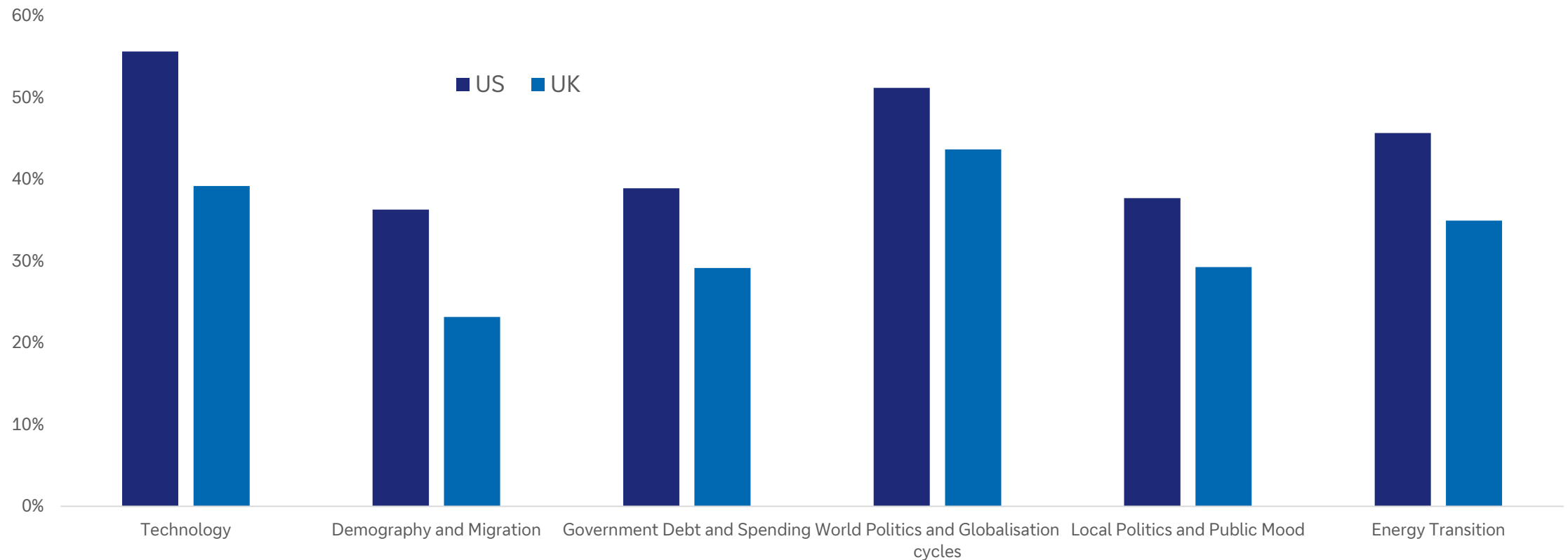
Source: dbDataInsights, Deutsche Bank.

Active management: Investor attention to megatrends seems to contradict the narrative that everyone is piling into passive indices.

Americans are more likely to actively manage their portfolios for megatrends, particularly for technology



Proportion of investors who have made a change to their investment portfolio in the last three years as a result of the following megatrends



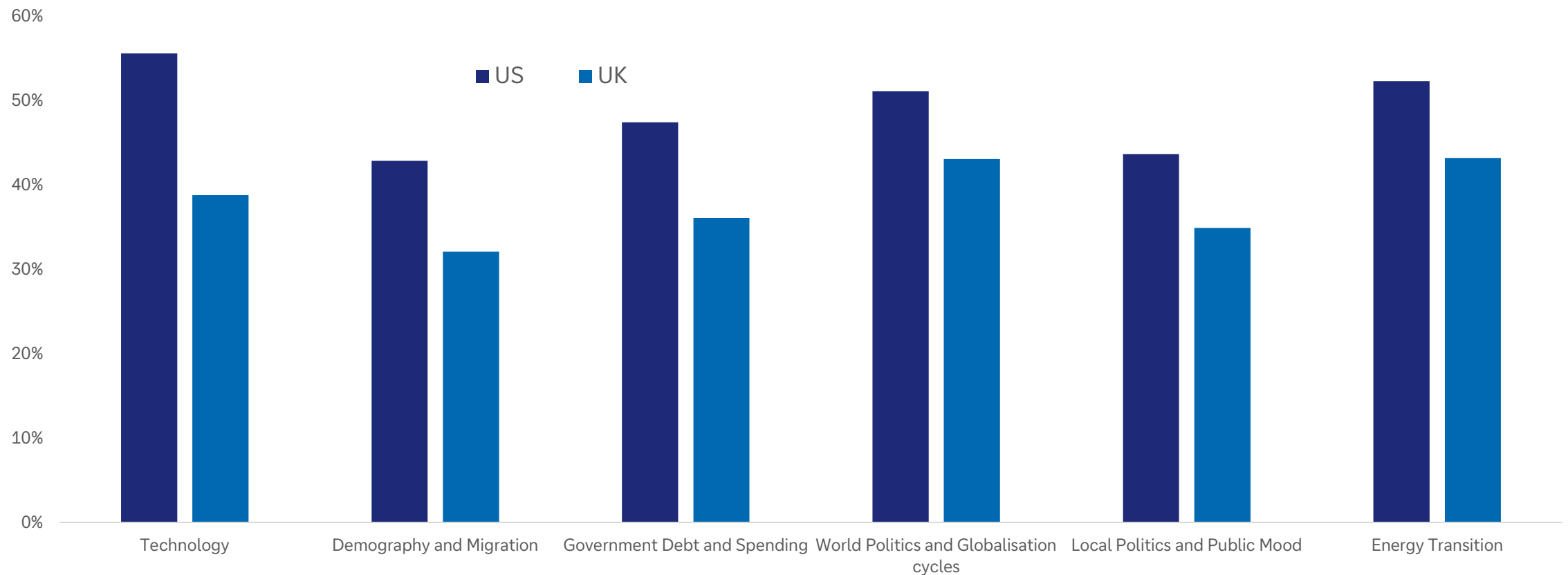
Source: dbDataInsights, Deutsche Bank.

Active management: The volatility of the last two years perhaps a key reason why investors continue to expect to make investment changes over the coming 12 months



No doubt volatility of global politics feeds into the decisions; however, the pace of AI adoption is also key

Proportion of investors who are 'likely' or 'very likely' to change their investment portfolio in the next 12 months as a result of the following megatrends



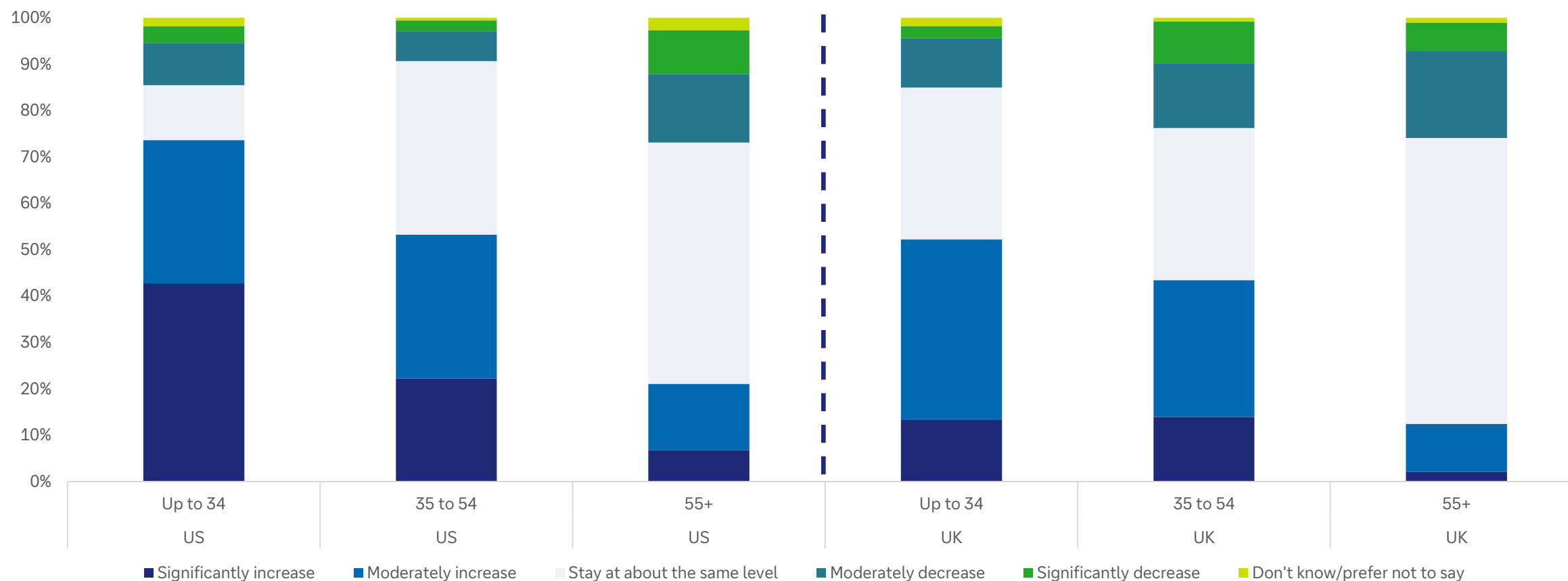
Source: dbDataInsights, Deutsche Bank.

Risk is back: Far more people expect to *increase* their risk taking over the coming 12 months

Despite the four major international shocks that have affected markets this decade, investors appear undeterred. Partly, this is due to enthusiasm about AI, but it may also be partly due to consistent way in which equity markets have rebounded after sharp shocks.



Over the next 1 year, do you expect your level of risk-taking in relation to your main investment portfolio to...

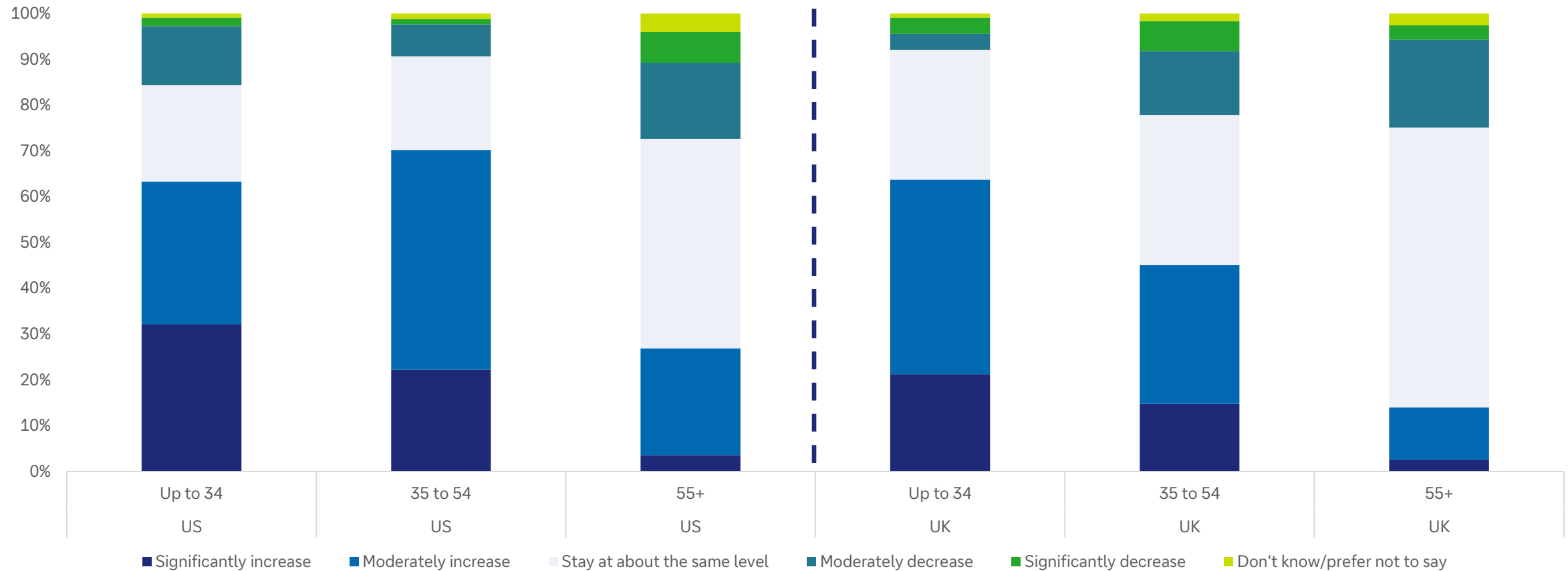


Source: dbDataInsights, Deutsche Bank.

Risk on: Three years out, expectations for risk taking are even stronger ...



Over the next 3 years, do you expect your level of risk-taking in relation to your main investment portfolio to...

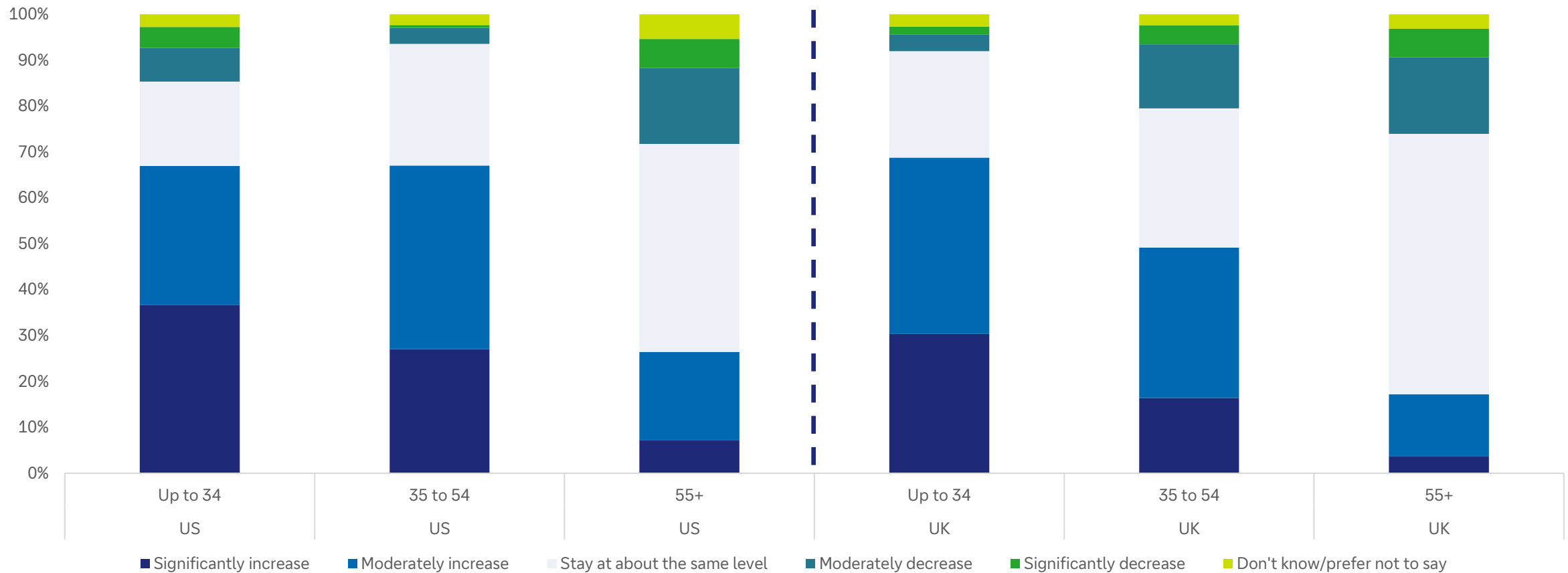


Source: dbDataInsights, Deutsche Bank.

... before risk tolerance plateaus into a 5-year timeframe



Over the next 5 years, do you expect your level of risk-taking in relation to your main investment portfolio to...



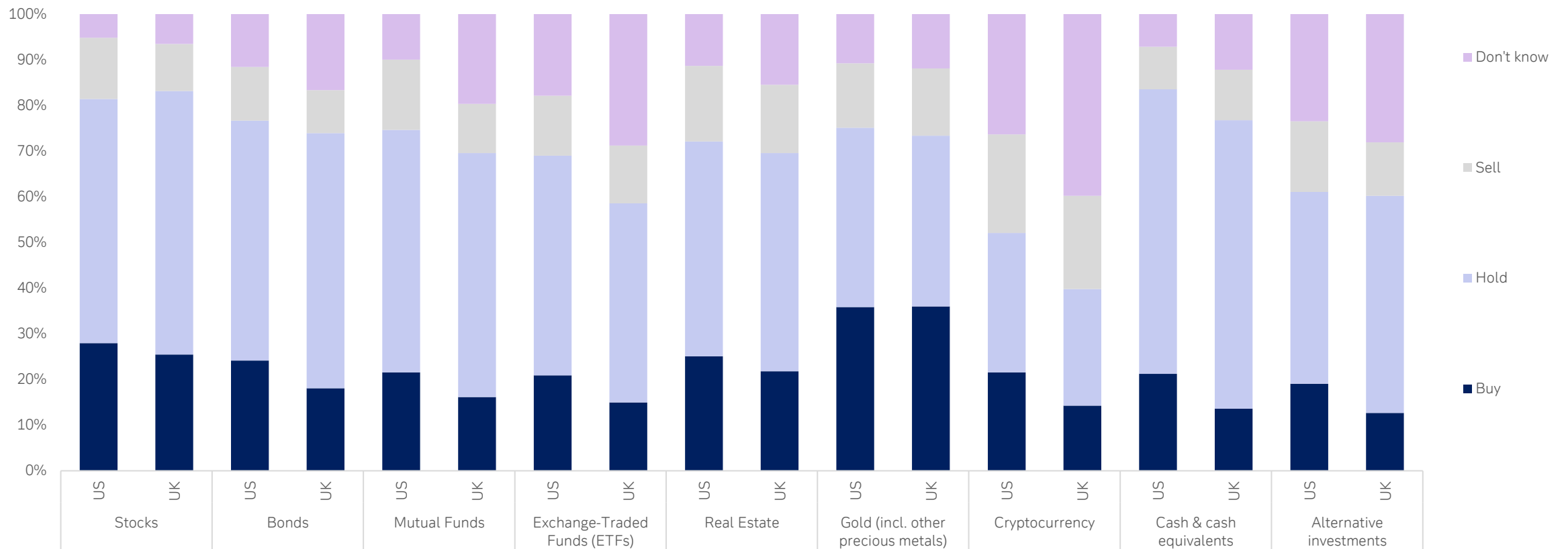
Source: dbDataInsights, Deutsche Bank.

What investors do when things are uncertain

The market volatility of the 2020s has been a great litmus test for how investors react to uncertainty. It is unexpected to see that equities are seen as a stronger 'buy' option than bonds



“In any period of economic uncertainty, what do you think is the best strategy for each of the following investment asset categories?”



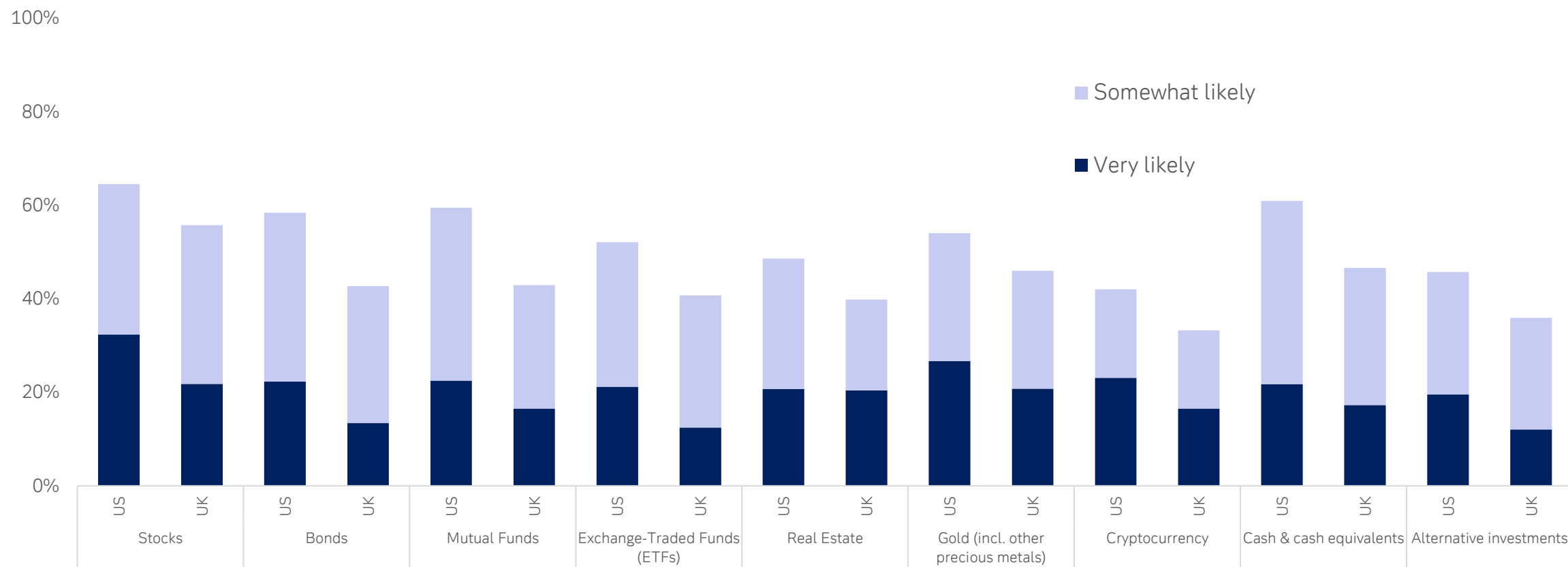
Source: dbDataInsights, Deutsche Bank.

Domestic politics can be highly correlated with economic growth ...

... but the response from individual investors may be more muted than many expect



“If your country’s government were to change in the near future, how likely or unlikely would you be to invest in each of the following asset categories?”



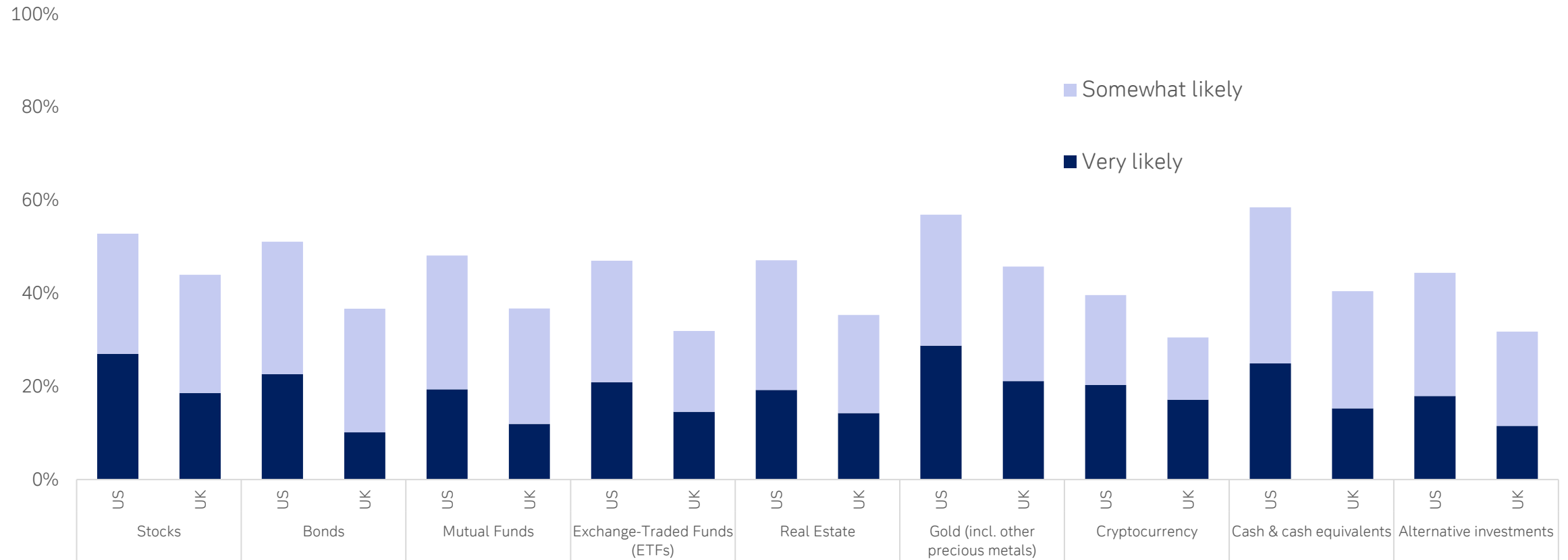
Source: dbDataInsights, Deutsche Bank.

Reacting to geopolitical uncertainty

Gold and cash are no surprise, but it is interesting to see that so many investors see equities as a geopolitical hedge. That may be another reaction to the rapid bounce-backs in equity markets this decade



“If tensions escalated between the US government and its major trading partners, how likely or unlikely would you be to invest in each of the following asset categories?”



Source: dbDataInsights, Deutsche Bank.



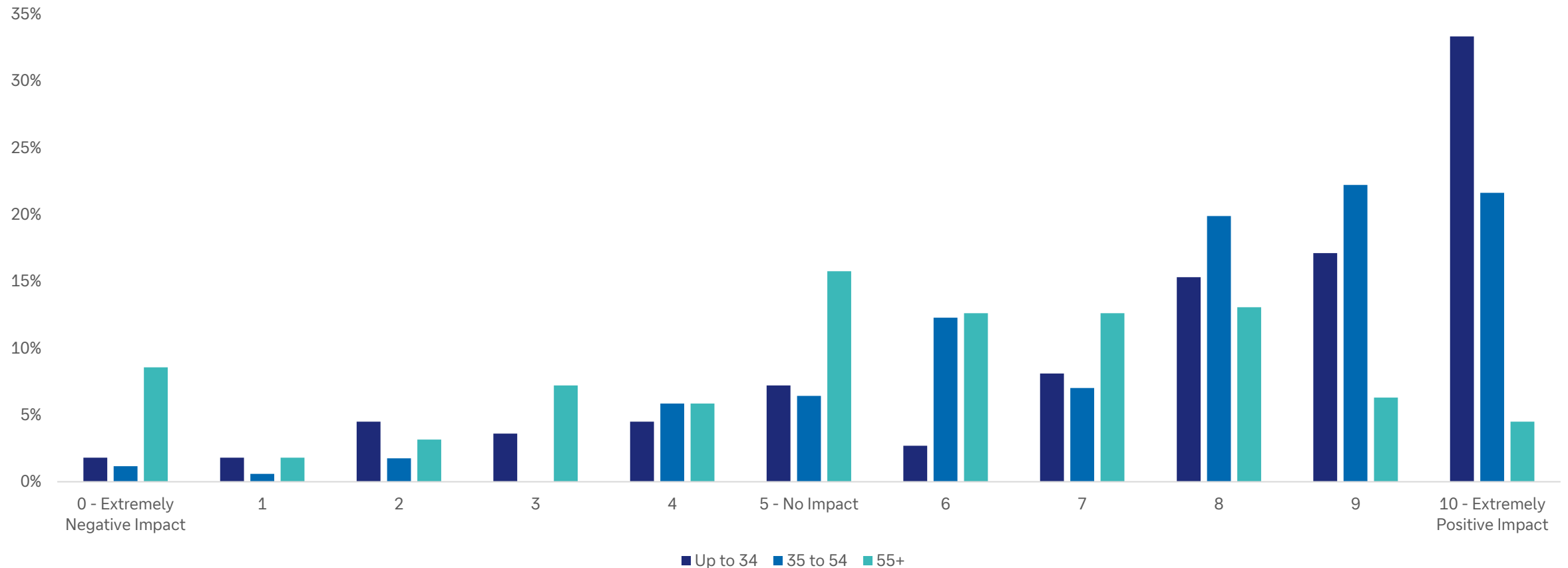
What investors think about individual
megatrends

Technology

Overwhelming optimism is the theme. The question is whether the returns will come from the specific assets to which investors are exposed, or from other more nuanced and diversified sources.



Investors' anticipated impact of technology on their main investment portfolio over the next 3 years (0-10)



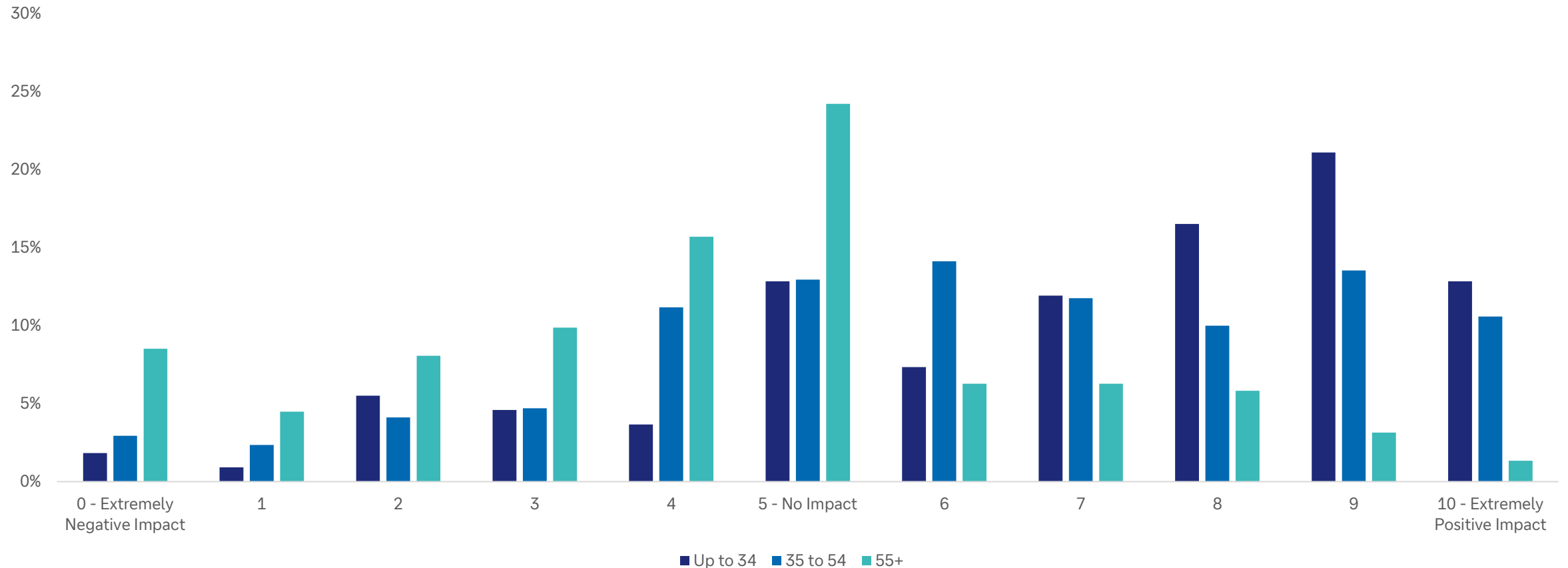
Source: dbDataInsights, Deutsche Bank.

Sovereign deficits

People are more optimistic than we expected about the impact of sovereign deficits. This may reflect an opinion that, somehow, governments will find a way to muddle through their current problems.



Investors' anticipated impact of sovereign deficits on their main investment portfolio over the next 3 years (0-10)



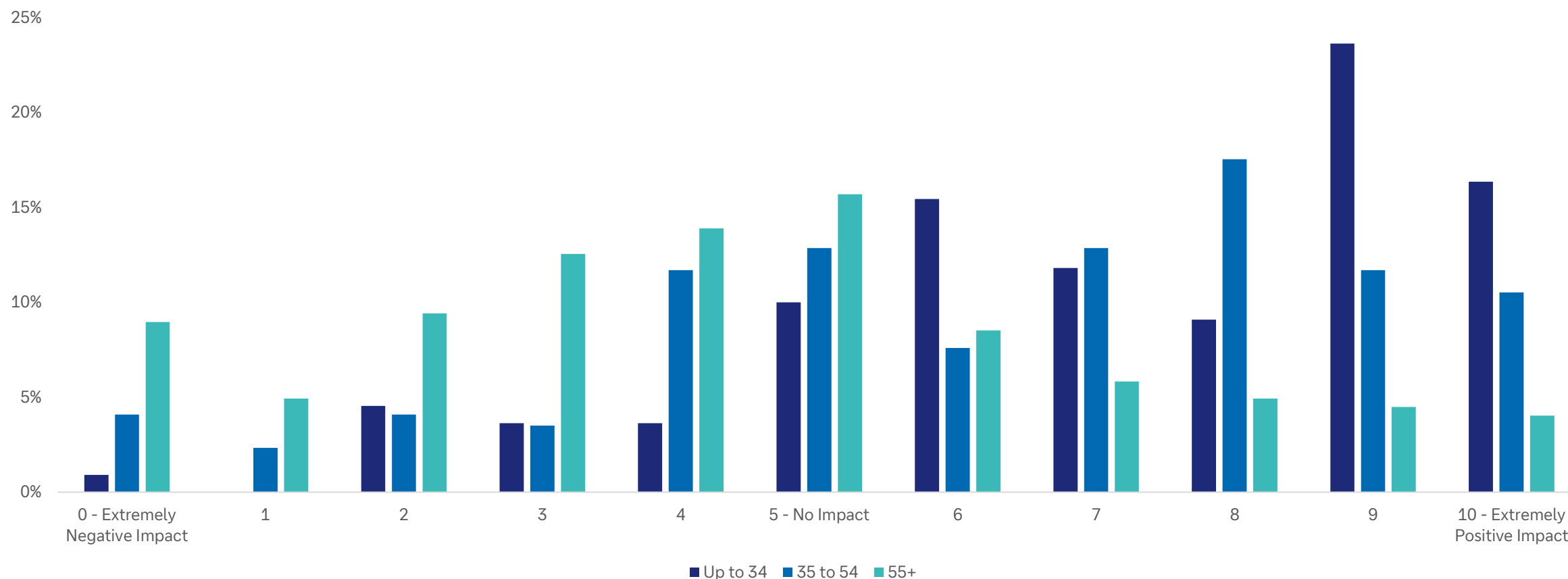
Source: dbDataInsights, Deutsche Bank.

Geopolitics & Globalisation

Perhaps the biggest surprise was that people generally expect geopolitics to have a positive impact on their investments. There are some strong arguments for this, particularly as trade has proved resilient to the recent tariff wars. However, it seems that most people expect current geopolitical conflict to resolve in their country's favour.



Investors' anticipated impact of geopolitics & globalisation on their main investment portfolio over the next 3 years (0-10)



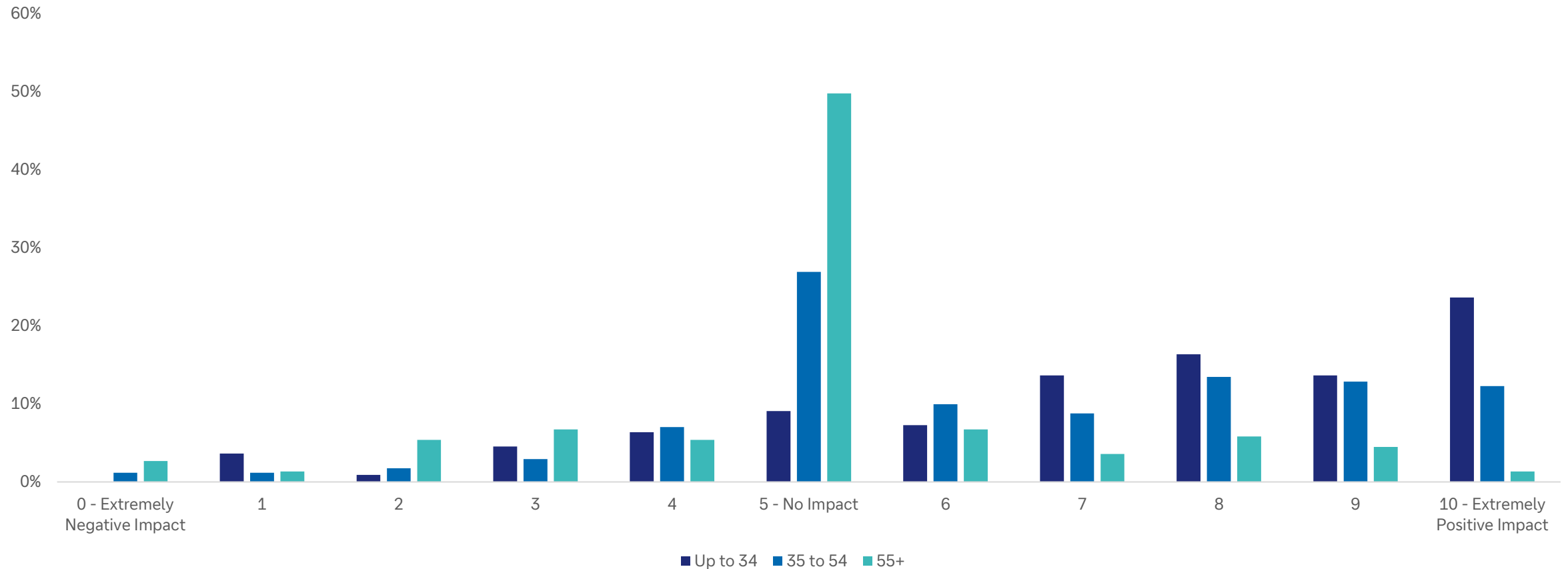
Source: dbDataInsights, Deutsche Bank.

Domestic politics & social unrest

Our model shows that domestic politics is heavily correlated with economic growth; however, investors do not rate it as a key investment factor.



Investors' anticipated impact of domestic politics & social unrest on their main investment portfolio over the next 3 years (0-10)



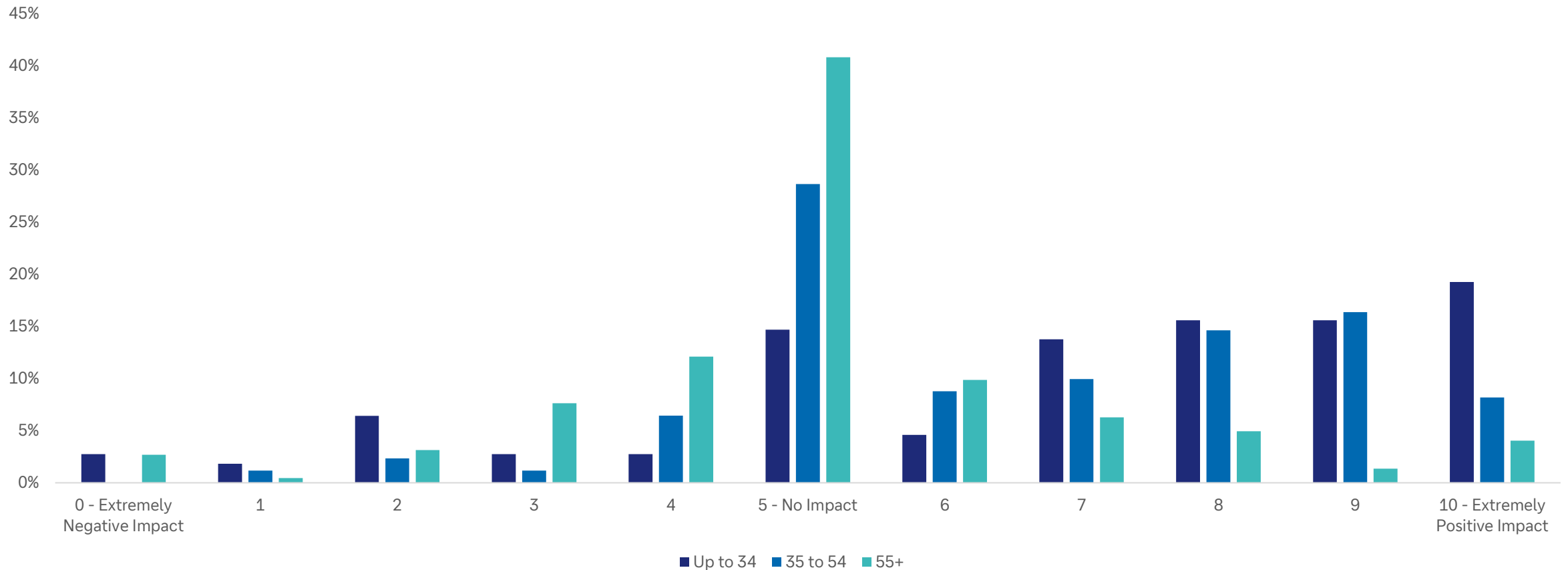
Source: dbDataInsights, Deutsche Bank.

Demography

Far more people are optimistic about demography. This also aligns with the positive tilt for sovereign deficits (which are deeply intertwined). To be fair, there are some underappreciated positive aspects to demography such as increasing healthspans and the consumer power of older people relative to those in the past.



Investors' anticipated impact of demography on their main investment portfolio over the next 3 years (0-10)



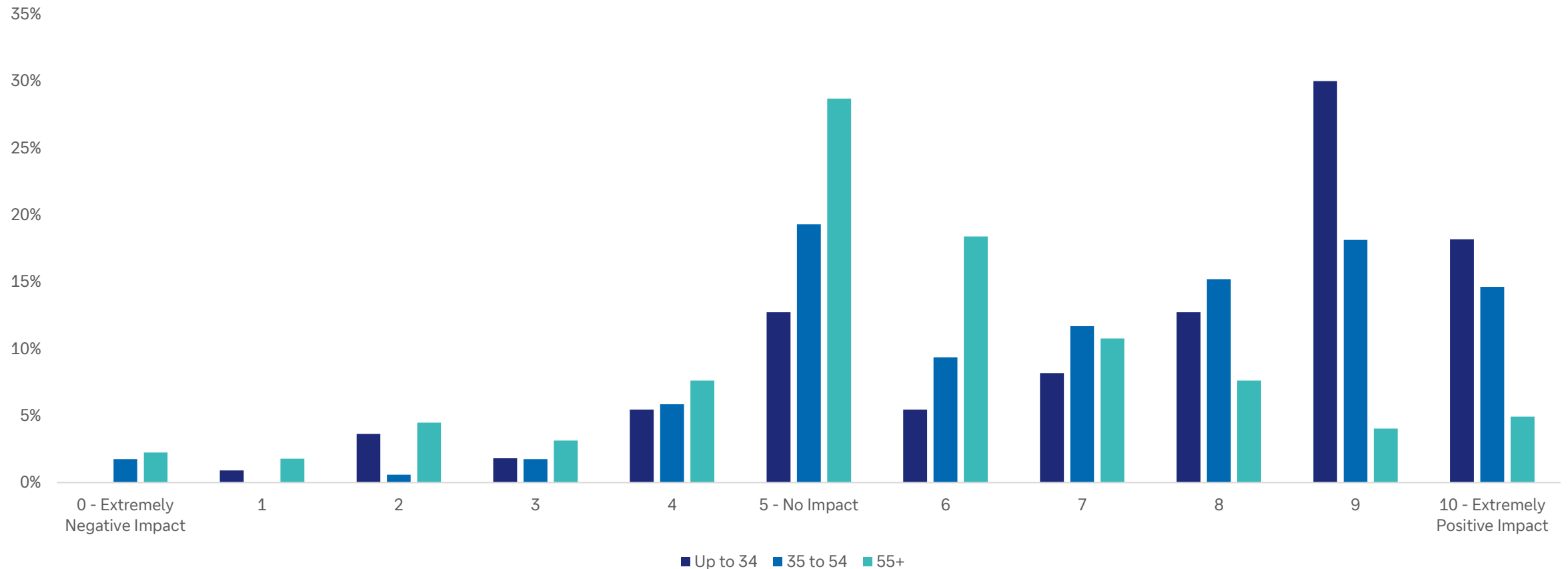
Source: dbDataInsights, Deutsche Bank.

Energy disruption & transition

There have been booms and busts in various alternative energy assets over the last decade. However, there is a strong realisation that energy (from all sources) will become increasingly important in an age of both AI and geopolitical weaponisation.



Investors' anticipated impact of the energy transition on their main investment portfolio over the next 3 years (0-10)



Source: dbDataInsights, Deutsche Bank.

Appendix 1



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